

Reducing Appointment No-shows: What the Research Says

A whitepaper by Remindly Research, 2025

Summary

Missed appointments cost healthcare providers between 5% and 15% of capacity. Across 31 published studies, automated reminders reduced no-shows by a median of 29%. Two reminders (one 2-3 days before, one on the day) worked better than one.

What works

- Reminders that include an easy way to cancel or move the appointment.
- Messages in the patient's own language.
- Sending reminders at a time the patient is likely to read them, for example 18:00.

What does not work

- Charging a no-show fee without a reminder; it harms trust and barely changes behaviour.
- Long messages with legal text.